

Chapter Title: AT THE THRESHOLD OF THIS LIFE

Book Title: The Ends of Kinship

Book Subtitle: Connecting Himalayan Lives between Nepal and New York

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Published by: University of Washington Press. (2020)

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctv17db3wk.18>

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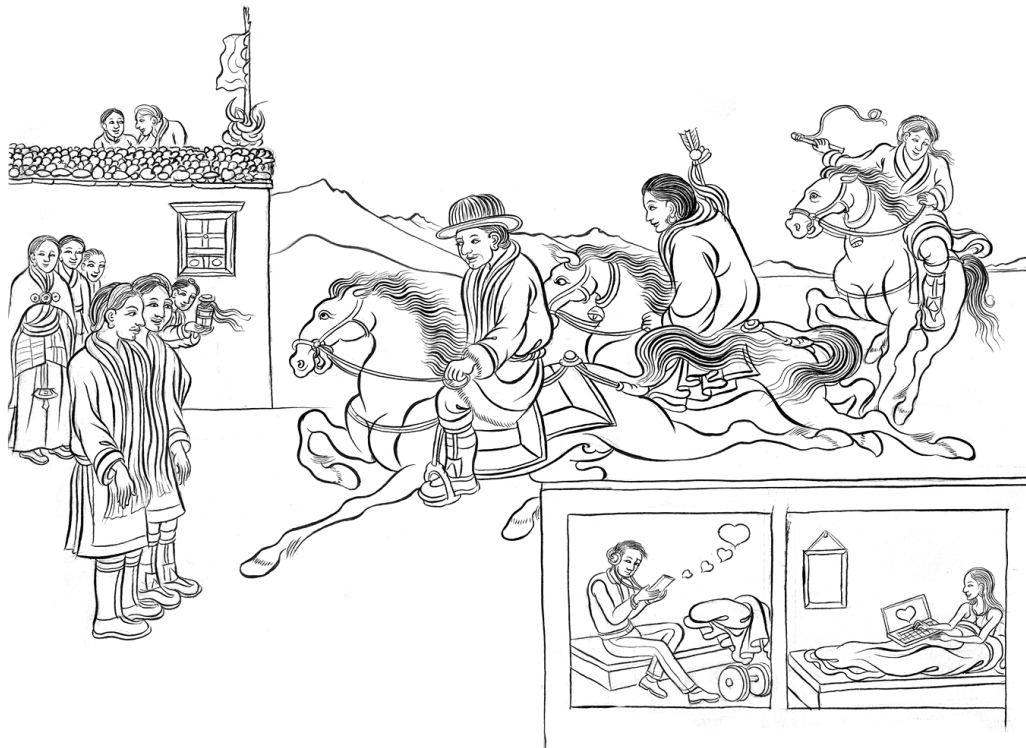


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PART IV

WOMEN AND MEN



I know there is no straight road
No straight road in this world
Only a giant labyrinth
Of intersecting crossroads

—FEDERICO GARCÍA LORCA, “FLOATING BRIDGES”

KINSHIP LIVES AT THE CROSSROADS OF BIOLOGICAL AND SOCIAL reproduction. It links women and men. In Mustang, as elsewhere, to marry

and have children are the mandates of householders. The circumstances of marriages and the social bonds created through matchmaking have at once changed and remained constant through the *khora* of migration. Movement recasts alliance and descent. Still, parents dig in their heels. Children comply, unless they rebel.

Anthropologists have long framed kinship as the foundation of belonging, identity, and rights—at once cultural and legal. Kinship travels. And yet *how* kinship travels can be complicated by new dynamics of mobility and attendant expectations about what unions are meant to accomplish, near and far. The *khora* of migration facilitates betrothal and betrayal, love and longing. In this and other ways, Mustang reflects what anthropologist Michael Herzfeld has called “the village in the world and the world in the village.”

In the short story, “Night Visitors,” Jigme is the eldest son in a family who needs a *nama*, a daughter-in-law. He is uncertain: of himself, of what love means, and of what marriage has to do with affection. He struggles to name an acceptable bride and, when he does, he wonders what sorts of happiness and suffering this choice will produce.

“At the Threshold of This Life,” the ethnographic chapter, takes its title from a Loba wedding song, *Tse Go La*. Like marriages themselves, each of these words holds multiple meanings: of life and lifespan, of doors and thresholds, of mountain passes and the soul. This chapter begins with a wedding ceremony that occurs in New York but that reinscribes family connections in Lo. Different forms of relationship are considered: love and arranged marriages, monks who become householders, polyandrous and cross-cousin matrimony. We glimpse the nuances of sex and gender in ways that do not necessarily conform to social norms. Finally, this chapter asks how parents back in Nepal wrestle with the possibility that their children will not return, that home is being built elsewhere.

AT THE THRESHOLD OF THIS LIFE

A GOOD MATCH

The wedding announcement came by mail, a thick gold lamé envelope lined in red. The card inside felicitated in English and Tibetan, with phrases as ornate as the lettering. Nyima and Dorje were getting married. I was one of nearly seven hundred guests invited to this event in March 2015.

The wedding party was to occur at a Manhattan venue known as the Armenian Hall. Unlike the Burmese Hall in Queens, which the community sometimes rents for other events—itsself not much more than a finished basement with folding tables and a built-in stage—the Armenian Hall is grand. Chandeliers, a dramatic staircase, fancy bathrooms. I had last been there for a Losar party some years before. I recalled the Nigerian security guards and the massive oil paintings depicting the Armenian diaspora on the walls. For that event, the stage was given over to a giant banner with Losar greetings in Nepali and Tibetan, against the backdrop of a slightly blurry reproduction of Lo Monthang. For a wedding party, the stage would turn into a shrine, complete with a portrait of the Dalai Lama and Sakya Gomang Rinpoche and a low divan on which Nyima and Dorje would sit for hours, alongside representatives of their families: a place to be praised, blessed, and buried in *kathag* before the formalities would give way to disco.

This *changsa*, an “exchange of beer” ceremony that marks a marriage, has been a long time coming. Nyima and Dorje were betrothed several years ago and already have a two-year-old daughter. However, a series of family deaths postponed this celebration. It is improper to celebrate the formal linking of households in a year also marked by death.

On the afternoon of the wedding, I dress in a *chuba* and the Mustang style of woven apron and head out from a friend’s place in the East Village. Although the wedding party won’t begin until this evening, I am expected at Dorje’s sister’s place in Queens, the home into which Nyima will now

move as a *nama*. There, the more private rituals, at once religious and sartorial, are taking place. At Grand Central, I discover that the 7 train is out of commission, so I walk back outside in this ethnic outfit, feeling self-conscious, to find a taxi.

The taxi driver is a Sherpa. “Namaste,” he says, without missing a beat. “Where are you going?” I explain, in Nepali, that I’m going to my *mithini*’s daughter’s wedding. A *mithini*, or *rokmo* in Logé, is a fictive sister. We are halfway through the Midtown Tunnel when he turns off the meter. “Just pay me what you think,” he says. I learn that he had been a trekking guide before coming to New York. He’s been to Mustang many times.

The taxi driver drops me off on a side street in front of a brick duplex not far from Queens Boulevard. I have been here once before, when Dorje’s brother Lobsang was visiting from Nepal. Lobsang is an old friend, and that was a quiet moment of conversation and reconnection. Now, the house is raucous. A landslide of shoes spills out over the threshold.

Women rush around, trying to find the right pins for their *chuba* and straightening the men’s fur-lined hats. Kunzom’s elder sister is at the helm in the kitchen. She smiles and greets me, her hands dishing out *dresil*, festive rice pudding, as fast as she can. The two bathrooms in this single-family home have been marked with “Ladies” and “Gents” signs. One of Nyima’s two younger sisters hardly acknowledges me as we pass in the hallway. I wonder what she thinks of this “auntie” with a connection to her homeland, itself a place where she has spent very little time.

The living room is lined in wood paneling. This, combined with the eight-foot ceilings, makes me feel as if we are on a ship together, sailing through seas at once familiar and new. It is an apt metaphor for the immigrant experience.

While the women cluster in the kitchen, most of the men are seated around the living room. The lack of alcohol is noticeable. Everyone is clear eyed—sober and felicitous, for now. I wonder how this moment might have played out differently had the wedding been in Mustang. I say hello to those I know, including two members of the Lo royal family who have come from Nepal for this wedding. This arranged partnership links two branches of Mustang nobility. The presence of these elite men lends the occasion a majestic air.

Such knottings bespeak the ends of kinship. Old ropes, newly tied, linking biology to social alliance in ways that keep status intact. The extended family into which Nyima is marrying owns this four-bedroom house. They

also own a mansion nestled up against the hills beyond Swayambhu in Kathmandu, and they are the inheritors of one of the palaces in Lo. In other words, they have done well when it comes to real estate.

Throughout the whirl of activity at the groom's house, little Sangmo, Nyima and Dorje's toddler, spins around in her fuchsia *chuba* like a sprite. She is passed between various aunts and cousins, sometimes crying for her mother. Aside from the Newari videographer and his crew, I am the only person not from Mustang in the place. I search for Nyima and her mother, Dolma. The bride is sequestered in a bedroom, her mother in attendance. Nyima looks radiant. Dolma offers me a warm embrace.

"Sangmo will have a memory of her mother's wedding," says Nyima. Her tone seems joyful yet tinged with embarrassment. Although the bride was raised in a household governed by strict Loba norms, and although all are proud of this union, I wonder if, in her years of working for white American families as babysitter, some other normative sensibility has lodged—one that recalls an old playground rhyme: *First comes love, then comes marriage, then comes the baby in the baby carriage.*

One of the groom's sisters helps Nyima dress. "How do you do this?" Nyima asks, laughing and fumbling with Tibetan boots, a form of cultural regalia that she has never worn.

"You look so young," says Nyima's sister-in-law. "What is your animal year?"

"Snake. In Western years, I am twenty-five. But in our years, I'm twenty-seven," Nyima responds. "My mother was twenty-five when she got married too."

"I was twenty-five when I married Ken," I offer.

"Really?" Nyima looks surprised. "Is that unusual for foreigners?" she says. We both laugh when she calls me *chikya*, foreigner, because I am not—and yet still sort of am—a foreigner here.

"Yes. Most of my close friends didn't get married until they were at least thirty," I answer.

"But you didn't have Aida until later, right?" asks Nyima.

"I was almost thirty-one," I answer, as I help Nyima fasten necklaces of turquoise, coral, and pearl.

"You must have taken medicine," says Nyima, speaking of birth control. I nod, and, although there is no reason for it, we each blush.

"And you only have one child?" the sister-in-law interjects.

"*Chika rang chik*, one and only one," I say, holding up a finger.

"*Nyingjé*," she says. "How lonely for her. For us, one is not enough. But now, more than three is too many."

I walk back upstairs and am greeted by a princess of Lo. Raised in Kathmandu, she is now attending university in the American South. The young woman's raven hair falls in ringlets down her back. Her lips are glossy and full. She clutches a Michael Kors bag. Her hot pink *chuba* is made of raw silk, offset by a cobalt blouse. She seems to float above the room: expected to be there but also somewhat out of place. She chats in English-Nepali with a cousin. They speak about college courses and majors, Nepali phrases peppered with "like" and "um" and "totally." Meanwhile, in the next room, the ritual singing has begun. Dorje and Nyima are dressed and seated in their places of honor. Their demeanor is composed.

Another member of the royal family comes up to me. "I think it has been twenty years since I've seen you, but I still remember. You were riding a black horse."

I feel that day in my bones. A thunderstorm was approaching. I was riding Lobsang's gelding alone. The horse was struggling against me, feeling that strangeness of an unfamiliar rider, perhaps even of gender. This young man and I had ridden together for a while. Earlier, during my first extended stay in Mustang, he flirted with me in his antique shop in Monthang and spoke of his desire to leave Nepal. Now he owns a gas station in Jersey City.

Gyaltsen, the young man I visited in New Hampshire in 2002, joins our conversation. Like all of us, he looks older, handsome in a slate fedora, carrying his three-year-old son. "Do you still ride horses?" he asks.

"When I can," I answer. The love I carry for horses is also an ache.

"She used to spend so much time with my father," Gyaltsen says to the other man. Gyaltsen's father is an expert horseman from whom I learned a lot when I was younger.

I mill around and find Yeshe Sangmo, the niece of an *amchi* with whom I've worked closely and someone trained as a Tibetan doctor herself. We hug, happy to see each other. She nannies for a living. Meanwhile, her two-year-old son lives with her mother-in-law in Kathmandu. I ask if she misses practicing medicine. Her answer is by turns despondent and practical. "I do miss it. But I had the chance to learn scriptures," she says, "to become literate in Tibetan, to benefit people. I still see patients sometimes, when they come to me."

By the time rituals are completed, it is well past the 7:30 p.m. start time for the party listed on the invitation, and we are still in Queens. I ask

Dorje's brother how we'll all get to the Armenian Hall on the Lower East Side. "Chartered bus," he answers. Soon thereafter, we are funneling out of the house into a tourist coach, complete with intercom and funny driver, decorated in *kathag* and auspicious symbols. As we leave the house, *chang* is offered, and women sing wedding songs. I joke with Dolma that instead of the bride's family arriving in a long train of horses for this wedding, we are all taking one giant metal animal to the site of celebration. Elder men in the groom's party end up in another car because the bus is overflowing. There are people in the aisles and on laps.

I sit in the very back of the bus with a young woman named Kunga. I know her father, a member of the royal family of Lo, but I have not met her before this evening. She admits that this is the first Loba wedding she has ever attended. We speak most comfortably in English.

"My parents have struggled so hard to give me and my siblings incredible opportunities for education. But it also means that I don't really know my culture—or I am just starting to learn it now. I went to boarding school in India from the time I was very young. I have never been to Mustang. It is strange to be learning about it at this point in my life, and here." Kunga came to the U.S. for college where she studied biomedical sciences. She is now working in data analysis and considering a PhD in neuroscience.

"My parents really want me to go on in medicine, so I took a lot of pre-med classes, but then I had to take an anatomy class, and it was just too hard cutting into a body. I knew that was not for me." Her admission evokes many thoughts: of the sanctity of a body's wholeness in some religious traditions, of the ritual dismemberment and feeding of bodies to vultures in the Tibetan practice of sky burial, of what "medicine" means across culture.

"I'm interested in neuro and psychiatry," she adds, "but this type of science is harder for my parents to understand. You know, the mental things." It is clear that she wants their approval for her life choices.

"There are many different ways to practice medicine," I say. "Focusing on mental health might be harder for your parents to accept, but it could be really helpful to the community." I think about the child of another friend who spiraled into serious mental illness, and the pain and stigma his behavior engendered, the difficulty in communicating to immigrant health services local categories of disease or the relationship between body and mind in Tibetan Buddhism.

"Are your parents pressuring you to marry?" I ask. We are, after all, in the middle of an arranged marriage ceremony of a young woman not unlike Kunga, if Kunga had not left Nepal for education.

“Not at this point. My mother does remind me that it is marrying time, that I am the right age. But since I have an elder sister, there is less pressure on me. She is working in London, where she also went to school. She really has no interest in getting married. So, I don’t have to worry. For now.”

We pull up in front of the Armenian Hall and file out into the night. Formal blessings are overseen by the abbot of Namgyal monastery. He has been here seeing donors and giving teachings, but the timing of this wedding is not a coincidence—just as the moment of the betrothal announcement had been coordinated between lamas in Nepal and the family in New York. Nyima and Dorje are blessed with butter and consecrated water. Tibetan trumpets sound into the Manhattan night. Marriage song spirals skyward.

We walk in and down the staircase, past images of another people’s diaspora, into the main hall. Moving slowly in this sea of bodies, I notice patterns of resemblance: the long, thin face of one branch of the royal family recast across dozens of young men in baggy jeans; the freckles and bright eyes of a Baragaon lineage reflected in a group of female cousins, each made up with fake eyelashes and perfect eyeliner; the oval face and prominent Buddha ears of yet another family tree scattered through the crowd; the high cheekbones, large head, and chiseled jaws of Lo nobility leading the procession. DNA is more than a double helix. It is a rope of relatedness. Here, too, are the ends of kinship.

The evening winds on. It is a long road of speeches, fried snacks, and cultural performance. At one point, Chimi, another well-educated cousin of Nyima’s, is compelled to speak. She is unmarried and in her mid-thirties, noticeably so. In the voice of a strong tenor, one that several generations back would have called loudly from rooftops, she says, “I would like to say something about this wonderful couple. But first I have to ask some questions. How many of you are in a love marriage?” A murmur waves through the crowd, and a few tentative hands go up. She repeats the question, in English and Nepali, and a few more hands raise. Then she asks, “How many of you are in *arranged marriage*?” Same thing. Only a few hands go up.

“Now I want you to think about what it would be like to have not known your wife or husband before you got engaged. I could not imagine that. But that is what it was like for this couple, before their families made arrangements.”

What Chimi says is true. There is a significant age difference between the bride and groom. Dorje left Nepal for New York in 1997; Nyima didn’t arrive until 2011. The woman on the stage continues, “And now look at them.

They are such a beautiful couple and family. They are honoring our culture by the choices they are making.”

I’m fascinated by this oratory. It affirms the importance of romantic love and the possibility of finding such love through an arranged marriage. Even so, her words valorize a social institution that she herself cannot imagine being part of, even as it is a practice she admires. Just as she sees trust and “heart understanding” in this couple, she also recognizes the power to reproduce certain forms of culture through marriage. Still, like an open secret, this speech points toward the shifting terrain of matrimony, not only in America but also in Nepal, where love that ends in a mutual agreement to form a household—*phorong-morong* in local parlance and what might be called a “common law” marriage elsewhere—is becoming the norm, particularly for people from less elite families.

As I listen to Chimi praise Nyima and Dorje, I hear a chorus of opinions from people I have interviewed about marriage. “Falling in love is a waste of time,” said one twenty-something educator. “Love affairs are something we do in hostels or during college life, but these don’t lead to marriage.” A middle-aged man from Baragaon opined, “Arranged marriage is practical. It helps society. If a girl marries a Bahun or Chettri or even a Sherpa for love, then she is lost to their world. *Love* or *arrange*, everyone will have more respect if they are both from Mustang. If someone marries a foreigner, they don’t care for their people.” This is countered by a young woman from Baragaon: “Sometimes I think that I will marry someone from my own place, but when I see the ways village people can behave, I think that being married to a *rongba* would be fine. A foreigner, maybe even better.” An unmarried and successful woman entrepreneur shares, “I saw so much conflict in marriage. I decided I wanted to stay single and take care of my parents. It was my decision. Many people came asking for my hand, but I didn’t want to get married.” An ex-monk in his sixties says, “I was first a monk. Then my father called me back to the household, and I got married with my brother. But then I eloped with another woman. Now I don’t have a needle to my name from my old house, but my heart-mind is peaceful.”

Although Chimi doesn’t speak of this, I consider how Nyima and Dorje’s marriage also reflects an *ani-ashang*, or cross-cousin, logic of union. They are distant cousins. Patrilineal bone, *rü*, does not cross, but they are still in relation. In Central Tibet, such an arrangement could be considered incestuous, but it is a preferred approach to marriage across much of the Himalaya. As with fraternal polyandry, it can help to accrue, secure, and preserve power and property. But what this practice means for people from

Mustang is changing too. I recall a conversation from 2012, with an older woman from Ghiling: “We used to think *ani-ashang* was best, but now we wonder. We used to know who everyone was, but with so many people leaving, it is more difficult to know lineage for certain. My son has told me about *gene*. I am curious about that.”

Chimi’s speech also reminds me that while marriage might include intimacy, it is not just an intimate act but rather one that emerges through collective ritual action, toward the maintenance of a particular form of being human together. Ever the anthropologist, I sketch kinship diagrams in my head as she speaks. It helps me visualize just how strategic this marriage is, how it fits within the other choices the bride’s and groom’s families have made. Dorje’s elder brother, Lobsang, married a woman from a high-status Baragaon family and, in so doing, repeated a pattern of alliance that could be Shakespearean, were it not rooted in Mustang.

It is 12:30 a.m. by the time dinner is served.

We make the transition from feast and culture show to formal ceremony. Lobsang gets up to give a speech. This man usually presents with a lot of Mustang machismo. But now he shakes as he speaks, nervous and moved. “Even here in this city far away from Mustang, we are still keeping our culture alive,” he begins. “We can see it in the ways that the young people are dancing and in how our language is being used here, the stories we are telling and the songs we are singing,” he says. “Did you know that there are about four thousand languages in the world, but one is dying every day? We cannot let that happen to our own language.” I think about Kunga and how on the bus ride earlier she admitted that she’s been exposed to more Logé in New York than ever before in her life.

Then, as a way of further illustrating that a wedding is never just about the couple in question, and that a wedding occurring in New York is never *only* occurring in New York, Lobsang adds a note of gratitude for those who have donated funds in honor of this auspicious event to his village. “I am proud that from New York there has come 25 *lakh* to support the mothers’ group. This makes me proud.” This is a significant amount of money—more than US\$25,000. And this is just from one event.

Among the many things I notice this evening, one is the sense that people are doing well here. Despite the fourteen-hour days at nail salons and visa debt, a sense of possibility pervades. I see the sister of a friend, a woman who has had a very difficult life. It has been years since we’ve visited. She looks healthy—what people from Mustang would call *gyakpa*, “fat,” but as a compliment. She talks about her babysitting job and how much she enjoys

being here. “The work is difficult, but it is nothing like what we did in Lo, the agricultural labor, dealing with village struggles.” Indeed, she looks about a decade younger than the last time I saw her and, even with the weight, lighter. Migration can be liberating, particularly for those on the bottom of a socioeconomic hierarchy. This is part of what makes the *khora* of migration also a quintessentially American story, bootstraps and all.

During the formal *kathag*-giving moment, guests file onto the stage to place scarves at the foot of the Dalai Lama’s image and then to Dorje, Nyima, and Dorje’s sister who is the designated attendant. It is with her that guests also deposit envelopes of cash—the proverbial nest egg. This ritual takes an hour and a half. A quick calculation indicates that more than three thousand *kathag* have been offered. By the end of the evening, they will be gathered up in garbage bags, plastic stuffed like a Michelin Man of merit.

As the other guests and I pass time together, I feel myself firmly rooted in the social slot of householder. No longer an apparition—a young, unmarried female spending time with older men who know about medicine and horses—I am now a full person, by virtue of my own marriage and motherhood. I am part of the space that Nyima and Dorje are moving into: of intimacy and obligation, of providence and care.

And yet I am also a specter. While welcomed and integrated into this scene, I remain a foreigner-not-foreigner who has a connection to the place that binds us all but that few of the younger generations know directly. I share these feelings with Dolma at some point this evening. “You *are* Mustang, so having you here is also like being in Mustang,” she answers. This is a sweet thing for her to say, even as it is untrue.

As I stand in line to offer my *kathag* and envelope to the new couple, I learn that I am standing behind Yangjin’s sister. We have only ever seen each other in pictures, but recognition comes like a camera flash. I tell her that I had such a wonderful time several months earlier at her family homes in Tshoshar and Marang. A look of wonder and confusion passes over her, as if she has seen a ghost.

The Loba emcee calls a “first dance.” However, unlike this practice at American weddings, in which the spotlight is on the bride and groom, here it is a moment of what anthropologist Victor Turner would call *communitas*: a state where all members of a community share a common experience that unite them in particular ways, often as an inversion of social norms. Members of the bride’s and groom’s families head to the floor. Dolma pulls me up, and we move together. It reminds me of the night, so many years

ago, when in the half-light of her home in Lo, in the presence of some in this room, we became a certain kind of sister to each other.

Some minutes later, Dolma and Nyima fall into a beautiful, bittersweet embrace. They cry in acknowledgment that this reconfiguration of households is now complete: a mother has, in a sense, lost a daughter. Formality dissolves into the simple act of loving and being loved, of care and longing. They hold each other beyond the specificities of time and place, even as they are enfolded, like their brocade gowns, within the fabric of culture.

As evening pushes toward morning, a kind of joy unfolds that seems distinct from the similar ritual moment in Mustang. All the elements of a traditional wedding ceremony have taken place. But a sense of sweet abandon pervades—emotion that seems less possible in Nepal. I watch a middle-aged husband and wife dance together under the disco ball. They move not within the regimented confines of village melody but as their bodies feel like it, to the rhythm of contemporary Nepali, Tibetan, and American pop tunes. One kind of mobility—the capacity to migrate—has allowed another kind of movement—a sense of playfulness and self-expression—to emerge.

THE BEST HUSBANDS

The first time I saw Wangyal in New York, it was difficult to recognize him. As he walked up behind me, his deep voice was familiar. “Eh, are you lost? This isn’t Mustang.” I turned around, under the subway tracks on Roosevelt Avenue, and encountered a householder: jeans, sweatshirt, a thick head of hair. But when this ex-monk smiled, his long face parted by dimples, I saw my teacher and my friend. “Come, let’s have tea,” he said.

A scholar of Mustang history and a monk in the Sakya tradition, Wangyal had been an attendant to the late Chopgye Trichen Rinpoche, himself connected to the royal family of Lo. But Wangyal was also the middle son of a very poor family. Political change and economic possibility felt out of reach for him in Nepal. When he got the opportunity to come to the U.S., he took it. That was nearly twenty years ago. As we sat that day in 2002, drinking milk tea in a Jackson Heights restaurant, I asked Wangyal if he still considered himself a monk. I cringe, in retrospect, at the awkwardness of my question, but I recall Wangyal’s graceful answer. “The day starts and ends for me the same. I sit, I read *peja*, I make offerings. What does it matter the clothes I wear?”

When I met Khandro, the woman who would become Wangyal's wife, I could tell that Wangyal was embarrassed. They were living together, along with Khandro's two cousins, in a flat in Elmhurst. They did not speak of each other as married, but she moved around him with a cherished sense of comportment that gave them away.

The next time I visited Wangyal and Khandro, she was visibly pregnant. "*Dralog* make the best husbands," Khandro said, as she lumbered around, preparing for her shift at a nail salon. "They are educated and kind, and they even know how to wash their own clothes!" We both laughed. "Some say that if a woman gets together with a *dralog*, then his sin transfers to her, but I don't believe it."

When I spent time with Wangyal in 2017, he held his adolescent son in his arms with affection. The boy was in the seventh grade, roughly the same age as my daughter, with a quirky smile and his father's dimples. He spoke mostly in English. Wangyal's mother-in-law sat on the couch across from us, spinning an upright prayer wheel. She was the better part of blind, but her hearing was good. "Who is that *chikya* who can speak?" she asked of the room and by which she meant speak *her* language.

"This is Rinzin Wangmo," Wangyal answered, using my Tibetan name. "She was once my student." As we talked, Wangyal shared news about the New York Mustang Association's aspirations to buy real estate for a community center in Queens, his involvement in running language and culture classes on his day off, the fact that he was sometimes called to do religious rituals for people. "Even *dralog* can be useful here," he said.

Wangyal scrolled through a social media forum on Mustang's religion and history that he helps to moderate. He held out his phone so that I could scan my QC code and join this virtual community.

"When we met, I was the scholar and you were the student," he mused. "Now you have a PhD, and I fill shelves with organic groceries all day long. What happened?"

"You are still a scholar," I responded. "And I am still learning."

SKETCHES OF MATRIMONY AND ITS OTHERS

The young man exudes the entitlement of someone whose mother brought him tea in bed for his entire childhood. He has never been to Mustang, but he claims his culturally Tibetan heritage when it is convenient, like when he learns that the owner of the coffee shop where he is training as a barista "*loves* the Dalai Lama." I ask him if he, now in his early twenties, has any

interest in marriage. He laughs. “Girlfriends are okay. But I just want to live my own life.”

The old *ngakpa* is a master of astrological calculations. Today, though, he calculates the dwindling population of his village, including members of this place now in New York, against the population of unmarried men. “We have ninety-four people left. It used to be ninety-six, but two died last year, and there were no births. Among these, there are twenty unmarried men. If they all married and had two children, we would have a future.”

Like the archery festival and midsummer harvest rituals, the annual soccer tournaments have become a venue for flirting, trysts. In villages with cellular signal, WeChat and Facebook help to facilitate liaisons. But people worry about the proliferation of *nyelu*, illegitimate children. A friend tells me, “Parents of daughters are now asking for *security deposit* of 1 *lakh* if a young man starts dating a daughter.” People learned this phrase from negotiating with landlords in New York and put it to use in Mustang. She explains that this arrangement provides financial security against raising a child alone. “It is protection. Like *condom*, but different.”

People say that the owner of a particular hotel is “like a woman.” He is married and has children, but he carries himself with effeminate flair. He is beautiful, keeps his hair long. I find myself wondering what he would look like in drag and what coming out in Mustang might mean.

I spend the afternoon in a Baragaon village making *momo* with a person who is dressed as a woman but whose long neck is marked by an Adam’s apple. This person lives, through the sociality of language, in feminine pronouns. She was born in this village and remains unmarried. Like other unmarried women, she sometimes does the work of men: trading, traveling. But she also does the work of women: caring for elders, tending to domestic life.

When a Baragaon noblewoman was literally dragged away at eighteen by her spouse-to-be and his posse on horseback, she was terrified. The first years proved hard, but she settled in eventually. Still, she calls this practice of bride capture “backwards” and wishes this cultural institution gone. She speaks of mothers’ groups and women’s rights. “Now people can report to the police, but there is still social pressure. If a girl is captured into marriage and then tries to leave, people call her unclean.”

A man in his fifties tells a *sasum* story. “When I was six, my mother passed away. My sister was already sent away as a *nama*. We only had my father, brother, and me. We needed a woman in the house, so my father arranged it. By that time, I was twelve, my brother was fifteen, and our wife was

eighteen. We didn't like her, but we bore one daughter. After several years, she returned to her home. We gave her property for the daughter, and we divorced. But now we are again a polyandrous family. My brother and I are married to one woman. This is a *love marriage*." I wonder, as he shares this narrative with me, how this second wife defines love.

The *amchi*, now sixtyish, tells me of his erstwhile lover, not the woman he married. Like others of his generation, marriage was a necessity, born of family circumstance and the need for labor. His admission reminds me of stories I've heard from his contemporaries: of drunken husbands and wicked stepmothers, of illness and betrayal and forbearance, of all the reasons why marital bonds form and all the reasons why they fray. "The younger people think marriage should be like a Bollywood film. This is an illusion."

A young man from Baragaon had a Tibetan girlfriend. He really liked this girl and told his parents. He thought they would be happy. Wouldn't marrying a Tibetan be a good thing? But they disapproved. He left the Tibetan and tried to find a local bride from Mustang. He succeeded, but he fell for a lower status person. Again, his parents rebuked his choice of girl, village, and family—even though they were all living in New York. The father threatened to disown him. The mother threatened suicide. People say that the young man lost his mind after these events. He still lives with his parents.

Nawang shares the story of a love affair gone awry. It is not his story, but he tells it anyway. The relationship began heady, filled with promises and affection. After the woman left for New York, the couple struggled with long-distance love—a love that the young woman's parents did not condone. Eventually, the couple's genuine commitment to each other was thwarted after the woman received her green card because her family needed the money that a "paper marriage" would fetch. Her immigration status was now a commodity: a fund that could pay for her mother's gall bladder operation and relieve family debt. The paper marriage did not undo the couple. Rather, a true proposal from a Loba family living in Kathmandu whose son was an accountant in New York did in the relationship. Although the woman didn't know the Loba accountant, her parents felt it was a better match than her long-distance love.

"It is so hard to plan a future, when marriage proposals can come not just from other villages but from across the world," says Nawang. "Marriage has always been about money, but now it is also like a *savings account*." He goes on speaking in Nepali peppered with English sentiments: *tragic*,

challenge, hidden love. “We are the *transit* generation,” he concludes. “Between one way of being together and the next.”

SPECTERS OF RETURN

The trail that leads up from the Kali Gandaki toward the Muktinath Valley wends past the hamlet of Khinga and into the village of Dzar. This path is hemmed in by stone walls on one side and the slope of a mountain on the other. Through the 1980s and 1990s, teahouses mushroomed along the trail. Some of these lodges were built of rammed earth; others were cast in cement. Petrified loaves of German bakery bread imported from Pokhara and dusty Snickers bars lined marigold-festooned windows. All boasted apple pancakes on their menus. Between April and November, these lodges welcomed a generous stream of trekkers. While several of these teahouses also functioned as homes, family households usually lay elsewhere, near the patchworks of barley, wheat, and buckwheat that blanketed the valley’s palm.

In those days, the trail was wide enough to accommodate horses, cows, and human traffic—but not abreast. Glacial runoff, when combined with summer rain, could turn parts of the path into bogs capable of sucking off horseshoes and hiking boots. Fog could linger on this side of the valley, even as sun streamed over the mountains and glinted off the roofs of Muktinath temples. Over the years, the path has widened to a road, accommodating tractors, motorcycles, and minibuses. Since the summer of 2017, it has run as a smooth ribbon of bitumen pitch, straight up from Kag. Some call this development.

One late September day in 2016, Kunzom, Yangjin, and I head down from Dzar toward Tsultrim and Rinzin’s apple orchard and farmhouse to join them for lunch. “Let’s go through the fields instead of the road,” Kunzom suggests. She’s just uprooted three plump turnips from her neighbor’s garden, wrung the necks of their leaves, and handed one each to Yangjin and me. “Sweetest around. Here, like this.” Her fingers work skin from flesh, peeling back the spindly root, making petals out of purple cellulose, turning the turnip into a lotus, before she bites in. “We used to do this as kids,” she says, holding the stump. “Mustang popsicle!” Her laugh leads us through a buckwheat field.

We’ve only been in Dzar for twenty-four hours, but I can already sense Kunzom’s ambivalence, the emotional wringing of hands that being here presents for her. This is the place where she was born and spent her early

childhood, the place where her father and several of her older siblings died, the place where ancestral responsibilities endure and houses have fallen into disrepair. Her family was the first to start a lodge in Dzar. In its day, this hotel stood as an architectural wonder, with its bank of glass windows, its sheltered garden and tidy dormitory rooms. Now, it stands as a reminder of the pace of change. Stone walls need tending. Apples spill across the yard. For the past few years, one of Kunzom's cousins has been revitalizing the lodge, keeping the mice at bay.

Tsultrim and Rinzin used to run a hotel too, just over a footbridge and down the irrigation canal from Kunzom's family lodge. Now, they have given up the hotelier life, reducing the footprint of their household to several rooms in this establishment. The remaining rooms are rented to lowland Nepalis from the much poorer district of Rukum who help Tsultrim and Rinzin plant, harvest, and care for livestock. What was once a rather grand common room now sits empty, save the platters of *churpi* and apricots spread out on the dining tables, drying in indirect sun.

This home that once bore a hotel plaque is not Tsultrim's ancestral household. That structure is tucked farther into this village, where houses fit together like puzzle pieces, winding around an old palace fortress. Vertical stands of cloud-colored prayer flags, *darchog*, mark the rooflines in Dzar, each flag representing a household member. These *darchog* are a certain metric of belonging, but they no longer account for people who live here. Ghostly cotton, riding the wind, they honor ancestors as much as they have become specters of those who are away and who may not return. So many young people have left Dzar that it is more common when one meets someone here under forty to presume that they are visiting from New York, Paris, or Kathmandu than it is to imagine that they live here.

I have known Tsultrim and Rinzin's family for as long as I've been coming to Mustang. With his baritone resonance that crackles into a high-pitched guffaw, Tsultrim possesses a worldliness even as he, a descendent of Dzar's lineage of headmen, remains a manager of village tradition and a man of power. Rinzin moves with graceful countenance, her high forehead lending an aristocratic air to this woman who has often worked until the point of collapse. Despite the possibilities that it could have been otherwise, Tsultrim and Rinzin love each other with a palpable tenderness, like first snow.

Theirs had been an arranged marriage and, eventually, a polyandrous one. Rinzin had wed Tsultrim, but when Tsultrim became deathly ill with tuberculosis, the parents of both parties persuaded Rinzin to also marry

Tsepak, Tsultrim's younger brother. It was a way of guarding against the hardship that would come if Tsultrim were to die. Fortunately, Tsultrim recovered. The union with Tsepak took root in small ways, with regard to intimacy. It is safe to say that one child of five is biologically his. But Tsultrim remains head of household, and they are all one close-knit family. Tsepak was part of the first wave of Mustang migrants to New York in the late 1990s.

"Tsultrim and Rinzin seem to be spending more time at the farmhouse," I say as we walk along the raised edge of a field.

"Sometimes it is more peaceful out of the village," says Kunzom. "Plus, they've got a lot to look after down there. Hundreds of apple trees. The Jersey cows." These corpulent bovines are a recent import and, one could argue, not only a prestige item but also a direct response to the shrinking labor pool. On my last trip to Dzar, Rinzin had explained the logic as she stroked the hide of a calf. "These cows are big and lazy. Like Americans. They sit around and eat, and then they give a lot of milk. You don't need many people to take care of them. Mustang cows are scrawny, and you need to chase them up and down the mountains. Like Nepalis!"

As we walk, I think about Tsultrim's mother. Nearing ninety, *ibi* Singye's back bends like a question mark. Her wrists and waist are as thin as a child's. Along with Rinzin's hundred-year-old mother who still lives in Jomsom, and Kunzom's ninety-nine-year-old mother in Kathmandu, Singye is the last of a generation who remembers the days when going to the capital city was like crossing over into another world.

"They have good help," Yangjin says. "But they must wonder what will happen when they get old. Will any of their children come back?"

Tsultrim and Rinzin's progeny all live in the U.S. The eldest daughter, married with a child, is a nurse. The eldest son, now with two kids of his own, works for a successful Baragaon businessman in Brooklyn. The middle daughter, once betrothed to the Muktinath nunnery, escaped this fate in no small part due to her father's efforts, against the grain of village tradition. She is now also a nurse and an unmarried free spirit. The youngest daughter has joined the U.S. Army, and the youngest son is an engineer.

"I don't think they will come back," Kunzom replies. "I mean, can *you* imagine any of them becoming farmers?"

"No, but I can see them feeling guilty," I say.

"At least two of them followed their parents' wishes about marriage," Yangjin notes. She is the only sibling in her family to remain in Nepal and would find herself, within the year, betrothed. Tsultrim and Rinzin's elder

son and daughter let their matches be made by parental negotiation. Each celebrated these unions in Nepal *and* New York. As these children stepped over the threshold into adult lives, they followed the form, if not the function, of what a Mustang marriage was supposed to be.

We near the edge of Tsultrim's property when Kunzom points down below.

"See that spot? Near the old apricot trees? That used to be my father's favorite place. He would spend days, weeks, down there in retreat, or sometimes just to get away from things—probably from my mom and all the kids! I loved spending time with him there." Kunzom is the youngest of thirteen children. The baby. The surprise that came when her mother was fifty. I imagine Kunzom's father playing with her as a grandparent might. "He would cook over an open fire and make plates out of stones. Everything seems more delicious when you eat off stone, with your hands."

We pass through the metal gate that marks the entrance to Tsultrim and Rinzin's apple orchard. The trees—more than three hundred of them—shine in shades of red and green, as if bedecked with jewels.

"Oh, *dzema la*, Mustang beauties! We're down here!" Tsultrim sounds a playful welcome. We find him lounging under a tree heavy with fruit. Once slim, he is still handsome, even though his belly has rounded over the years. Tsultrim gives me a bear hug, asks after my family.

"Come. Let me show you how things are growing." We've all been here before, but we indulge Tsultrim in this tour. He is wearing stained khaki pants and dress loafers, the soles worn thin. He clasps his hands behind his back as he walks. "Golden and Red Delicious. Gala. Fuji. Cortland. I've invested in more saplings this year. Some of them are doing well but others . . . I think we need to give them more love. And more Jersey cow shit." We all laugh.

Kunzom reaches up for a Golden Delicious. "Mustang apples may not be like *yartsa gunbu*," she says speaking of the *cordyceps* caterpillar fungus—aka Himalayan Viagra—that is worth more than its weight in gold, "but they are another way to make a lot of money," she says between bites.

"True," Tsultrim answers. "The price we can get per kilo has been increasing," he glances over his shoulder, toward the road, "because the cost of transportation is going down."

The last time I was here, two years ago, Tsultrim had looked up at the sky and shouted, as if to reach his eldest son across the seas, "Lhundup! This is your inheritance. It is waiting for you." This time, there was no such

proclamation. Instead, Tsultrim says, “I’m setting this up so that it will be a good investment for someone.”

“For Lhundup?” I ask.

“If he wants it. Or if any of the kids want it. Or someone else. I cannot predict.” My friend is serious now. “But it will bring a good income. I’ve tried to make them something worth coming back for, but who knows—”

I think about the conversation we had the other night in Kag with a relative of Tsultrim’s, as she held court in her home. This gorgeous noblewoman, whom I’ve had the privilege to watch age, was exhausted after working in her garden all day. She lounged on a platform bed, scratched her armpit with immodest alacrity, and declared, “The best ideas come from those who go out and then return. They lose their laziness abroad, and then come back appreciating how hard we work here. They carry in new ideas.” She rubbed her arthritic hands. “When do young people ever see the work before then? They’re off to boarding school before they learn to wipe snot from their noses. Problem is,” she mused, tucking in her heels and leaning forward, “The ones who go hardly ever come back. And the ones who marry over there—forget it!”

We tour the remaining rows of Tsultrim’s new saplings in silence. “Let’s go see the Jersey cows,” I suggest.

Rinzin is washing rainbow chard by the water spigot outside the farmhouse. She looks up and smiles. This time it is my turn to ask after her health. She’s suffered from various problems recently. “Are you well?”

“I am well. Come inside. Eat.”

We enter the new home. With its pitched roof and fancy bathrooms, it recalls a Swiss chalet. Tsultrim designed this structure to represent his imagination of an American farmhouse. I think that the pitched metal roof is a smart addition, given the ways that weather patterns are changing in Mustang. We sit on mattresses on the floor, drinking milk tea and chatting with Rinzin as she cooks up pumpkin curry and sautés chard. The pressure cooker whistles. Lunch is ready.

On a previous trip to Mustang, in 2014, I had found Rinzin presiding over the annual sea buckthorn harvest, working with her fellow village women to press and bottle this brambly berry into currency. The mothers’ group gathered in the Dzar community house. They grumbled as they worked about how old they were getting, how little help they had. A sense of abandonment filled the hall, like vapor rising from the vats of sea buckthorn juice: pungent and overpowering. To this, Rinzin offered, “It is our

right to tell our children to come back. Do they have no shame?" Others chided her, gently. "You know we can't control what they do."

Now, Rinzin serves up a feast in this sturdy house, built on uncertainty. We eat until our stomachs bulge and then take naps in the dappled shade of someone else's future.